> These learned men described the land known as India as a rhomboid, an unequal quadrilateral, in shape, with the Indus to the West, the mountains to the North and the sea on the East and the South.
>
> Cunningham goes on to write:
>
> The close agreement of these dimensions, given by Alexander's informants, with the actual size of the country is very remarkable and shows that the Indians, even at that early date in their history, had a very accurate knowledge of the form and extent of their native land.

I cite this historical and, yes, mythological, background to dispel the notion that Indians have never had a shared identity beyond a certain cultural and religious affinity, or that this affinity never found political expression rooted in a defined geography.

The Mahabharata and the Ramayana also unfold across what may be called a 'sacred geography'. [1] The invading Mughals and then the British (notwithstanding Strachey) assumed the mantle of rule over a land and people that for millennia had had a universally acknowledged identity as India. Mughal emperors like Akbar and Jehangir commissioned Persian translations of the Mahabharata and the Ramayana. These translations contained commentaries that sought legitimacy for Mughal rule as positioned in a long line of empires and kings dating back to remote antiquity; rulers of the geographic space called India. Akbar's conquests were compared to Yudhishtira's and Lord Rama's *asvamedha* sacrifices as the indispensable ritual for a *chakravartin* or universal ruler. [2]

~

We are familiar with Kautilya's *Arthashastra* of the fourth century BCE , but *arthashastra* or the science of governance draws on even older treatises. Kautilya himself refers to them. A later work in Sanskrit, the *Nitisara* of Kamandaki, probably dating to the fourth or fifth century CE , more specifically refers to several older works and authors, as also to the different theories propounded by them. [3] Interstate relations figured in these works as an essential part of statecraft.